20 Household Items That Can Help You Survive an Emergency



Summary

Most homes already contain household items that can help you survive an emergency. Everyday objects like tuna cans, frisbees, dental floss, and prescription bottles can help you start fires, filter water, treat injuries, build shelter, and handle power outages or survival situations when traditional gear isn't available.

What Household Emergency Hacks Actually Work in a Crisis?

The best emergency hacks use common household items—things already in your bathroom, junk drawer, pantry, or garage—to address critical survival needs like wound care, fire starting, water filtration, shelter, and signaling for help.

If you don't have a fully stocked bug-out bag, you can still survive an emergency if you know how to use what you already have.

The emergency hacks below aren't novelties.

They're legitimate tools that military medics, wilderness survival instructors, and experienced self-reliant families have used for decades.

And they’re hiding in plain sight in most of our homes.

#1 Turn Canned Tuna in Oil into an Emergency Candle



A can of oil-packed tuna can burn for at least an hour as an emergency lamp.

Punch a small hole in the lid.

Push a piece of string, a strip of cotton cloth, or a twisted paper towel through as a wick. Make sure it reaches the bottom of the can so it draws the oil up.

Let it soak for a few minutes, then light it.

The oil fuels the flame. The tuna stays intact and is still edible when the oil burns off.

It won't light up a room, but it will give you enough light to navigate, treat a wound, or keep panic from setting in when the grid goes down.



#2 Use a Frisbee to Collect Water, Dig Soil, or Signal for Rescue

A Frisbee can collect rainwater, dig loose soil, carry supplies, and reflect sunlight for emergency signaling during survival situations.

Set it out during rain to collect water, or use the edge to dig a small fire pit or hole in soft ground.

It also works as a lightweight camp plate or gear tray.

In rescue situations, the smooth plastic surface can reflect sunlight toward aircraft, vehicles, or distant search teams to attract attention.

#3 Use Coffee Filters to Pre-Filter Dirty Water in an Emergency



A coffee filter can remove sediment, debris, and visible particulates from water, but it will not make water safe to drink on its own.

Pour murky water through a coffee filter into a container first to remove the visible material.

Then boil or treat with purification tablets.

Skipping the pre-filter step reduces how well those treatments work. The coffee filter is step one, but NOT the whole solution.

Coffee filters also work as fire tinder, makeshift bandage padding, and emergency food strainers.



#4 Why Petroleum Jelly and Cotton Balls Are One of the Best DIY Fire Starters

A petroleum jelly-coated cotton ball ignites easily, burns hot, and keeps burning even in wind and wet conditions where matches fail.

The key is full coverage.

Coat the entire cotton ball so the petroleum jelly creates a waterproof shell around the fibers. That's what makes it wind and weather resistant.

#5 Use Pantyhose for Water Filtration, Gear Repair, and First Aid



Pantyhose can help pre-filter dirty water, secure bandages, prevent blisters, and repair gear during emergencies.

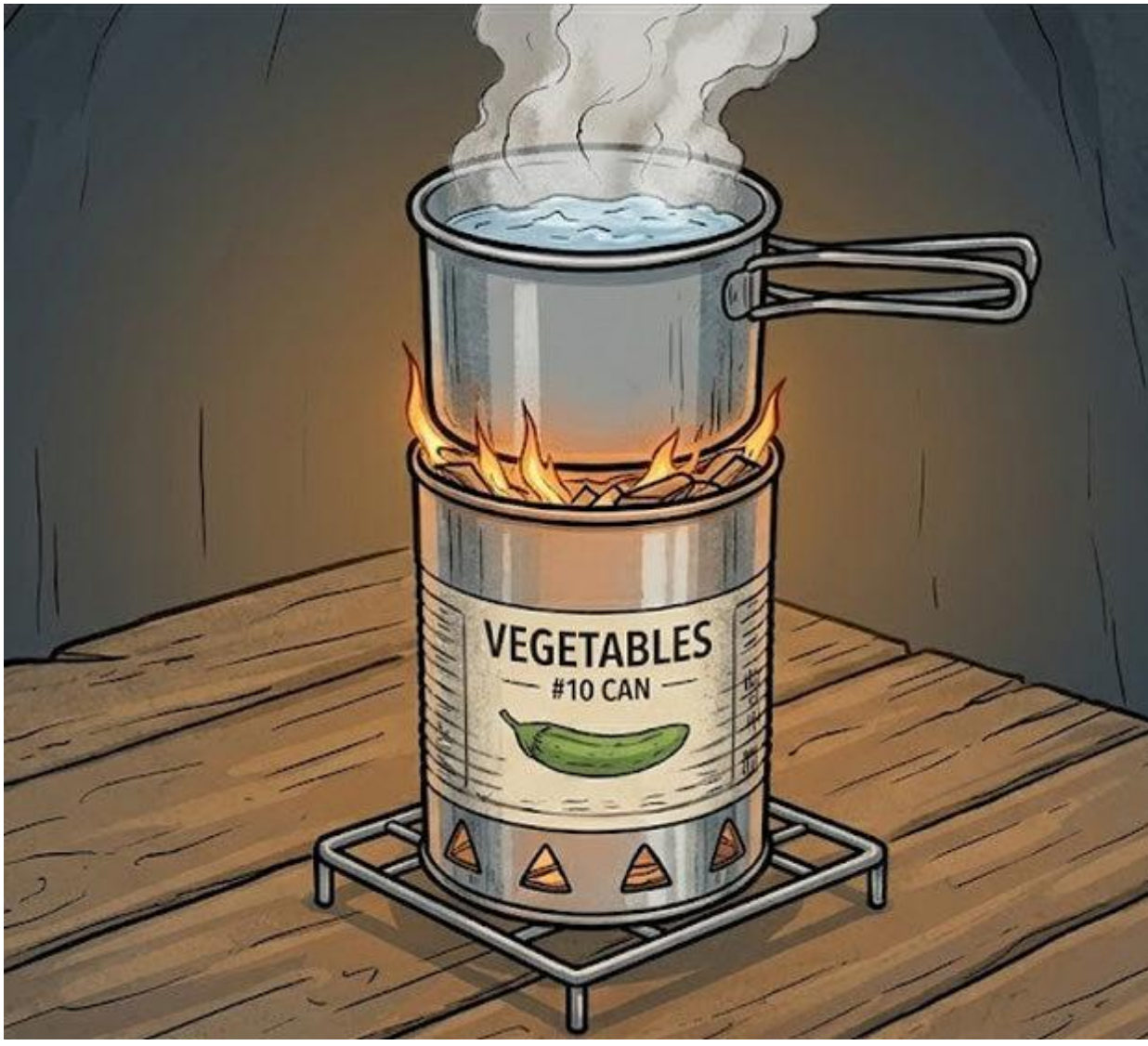
Stretch them over a container to remove sediment and visible debris from water before boiling or chemical treatment.

They can also improvise a sling, bundle supplies, or protect skin from friction during long evacuations.

In wilderness situations, pantyhose can function as a makeshift net or insect barrier.

Vietnam-era Navy SEALs reportedly wore them under clothing to help protect against leeches and biting insects.

#6 How to Turn a #10 Can into a Survival Stove or Cooking Pot



A #10 can functions as an emergency stove, cooking pot, water boiler, or improvised heater during power outages and survival situations.

Punch ventilation holes near the base for airflow, add a fuel source like wood chips, charcoal, or InstaFire, and the can becomes a simple camp stove for cooking or boiling water.

It can be used to reheat food and store small survival supplies between uses.

If you stock My Patriot Supply emergency food in #10 cans, don't throw them away when they're empty. They're one of the most useful containers in a grid-down emergency.

#7 Use Old Shoe Insoles for Emergency Insulation

Old shoe insoles can provide emergency insulation for your feet, hands, or sleeping area during cold-weather survival situations and power outages.

Place spare insoles inside boots to add warmth and reduce heat loss during winter emergencies or long evacuations.

They can also be wrapped around water bottles to help prevent freezing or used as padding beneath knees, elbows, or hips when sleeping on cold ground.

Foam and gel insoles dry quickly, weigh almost nothing, and take up very little space in a vehicle emergency kit or camping bag.

#8 Crayon Stubs Can Burn for 15 to 30 Minutes as Emergency Candles

Crayon stubs can function as small emergency candles during power outages and survival situations because the wax acts as fuel and the paper wrapper works as a wick.

To use one, soften the flat bottom over a small flame until it can stand upright, then light the paper tip.

Most crayons burn for approximately 15 to 30 minutes depending on size and brand.

Crayons may produce light soot and odor while burning, which is normal.

Crayola does not recommend using crayons as candles because they were not designed or safety-tested for that purpose.

Use them only as an emergency lighting option.

A box of broken crayons can provide hours of backup light during blackouts. Store a few in your vehicle, emergency kit, or camping supplies.



#9 Empty Prescription Bottles Make Waterproof Survival Containers

Empty prescription bottles can store matches, fire tinder, fishing gear, emergency cash, and other small survival supplies while protecting them from water, dirt, and damage.

The airtight plastic containers are lightweight, durable, and compact enough to fit in a pocket, glove box, go-bag, or hiking pack.

Fill one with waterproof matches and striker strips, or build a small emergency fishing kit using hooks, line, and sinkers.

Prescription bottles also work well for storing medication, batteries, cotton balls, or other supplies that need to stay dry during emergencies.

Label each bottle clearly and keep several in your vehicle, emergency kit, and camping gear.

#10 A Broken Umbrella Can Become a Shelter Frame, Digging Tool, or Emergency Survival Aid

A broken umbrella can provide shelter materials, digging tools, structural supports, and improvised survival gear during emergencies.

The metal spokes work as tent stakes, shelter supports, or structural bracing when tied together. The waterproof fabric can cover gear, protect a backpack from rain, or be cut into strips for improvised cordage.

Umbrella handles can also function as walking sticks, digging tools, or the base for an improvised spear in wilderness situations.

Instead of throwing a broken umbrella away, keep it as a lightweight emergency parts kit for your vehicle, camping gear, or survival supplies.



#11 Use Dental Floss for Fishing, Repairs, and Emergency Survival Tasks

Dental floss can function as fishing line, repair cordage, shelter lashing, sewing thread, and emergency gear tie-downs during survival

situations.

The lightweight cord is strong, compact, and small enough to fit easily in a pocket, go-bag, vehicle emergency kit, or camping pack. Use it to repair torn clothing, secure shelter poles, hang food away from wildlife, or improvise a small-game snare.

Waxed dental floss is stronger and more water-resistant than unwaxed varieties, making it the better option for emergency preparedness kits.

A single container provides yards of durable cordage while taking up almost no space.

#12 Use Maxi Pads as Emergency Bandages and Trauma Dressings

Maxi pads can function as emergency bandages for large cuts, burns, and bleeding injuries because they are highly absorbent and designed to stay in place.

Place a pad directly over the wound and secure it with duct tape, cloth, or a torn shirt.

The absorbent material helps control bleeding, while the adhesive backing on many pads helps prevent shifting during movement.

Maxi pads often absorb more fluid than standard adhesive bandages and conform better to larger injuries or awkward body areas.

#13 Turn Soda Can Tabs into Emergency Fishing Hooks

Soda can tabs can be cut and sharpened into small emergency fishing hooks during survival situations when standard gear is unavailable.

Use a knife or multi-tool to cut the bottom hole of the tab at a slant, removing metal to create a hook shape.

Sharpen the point on a rough rock or concrete.

Tie the finished hook through the top hole to dental floss, fishing line, or thin cordage.

Best for small fish as the aluminum bends under the weight of larger fish, so set realistic expectations in

a survival situation.



#14 Use Wine Corks as Fishing Bobbers and Emergency Fire Starters

Wine corks can function as fishing bobbers and compact fire starters during emergencies and survival situations.

Because cork naturally floats, it works well as a lightweight fishing bobber.

Thread fishing line through the center and secure it at the desired depth to help detect movement and bites while fishing.

Natural corks—not synthetic—can also be soaked in rubbing alcohol to create emergency fire starters.

Soak them in a sealed jar for at least several days, ideally a week, for best results.

Once ignited, the alcohol-saturated cork sustains a flame long enough to light dry tinder and kindling

in difficult conditions.

#15 Super Glue Can Temporarily Seal Minor Cuts in an Emergency

Super glue can temporarily close small, clean cuts during emergencies by holding the skin together and helping stop bleeding until proper medical care is available.

Medical professionals use surgical adhesives made from cyanoacrylate, the same base chemical found in household super glue.

In survival or field situations, a small amount can help seal minor cuts on fingers or hands and reduce dirt exposure.

**Household super glue is NOT a replacement for medical treatment and should NOT be used on deep wounds, infected cuts, punctures, animal bites, or injuries that require stitches.

#16 A Shower Curtain Can Become an Emergency Shelter or Rain Catcher

A shower curtain can function as an emergency shelter, rain catcher, ground cover, or waterproof barrier during survival situations and power outages.

The waterproof material works like a lightweight tarp and can be tied between trees or poles to create a lean-to shelter. It can also be worn as a rain poncho or spread on the ground to block moisture beneath a sleeping area.

The pre-punched holes along the top edge make it easy to secure with rope, paracord, or improvised cordage without additional modifications.

During vehicle emergencies, a shower curtain can cover broken windows, protect supplies from rain, or collect rainwater for emergency use.



#17 Cat Litter Can Improve Traction and Emergency Sanitation

Cat litter can help vehicles gain traction on ice or mud and can also function as an emergency

sanitation solution during power outages or grid-down situations.

Pour non-clumping cat litter under stuck tires to improve grip on snow, slush, mud, or light ice. For best results, clear away as much smooth ice as possible before applying. Keeping a small bag in your vehicle during winter can help you get unstuck during roadside emergencies.

In situations without running water or plumbing, cat litter can also turn a lined 5-gallon bucket into a basic emergency toilet system by absorbing moisture and reducing odor.

#18 Lip Balm Can Help You Start a Fire Faster

Lip balm can help start fires by extending burn time and giving tinder more fuel to hold a flame during emergencies and survival situations.

Petroleum- and wax-based lip balms work as compact fire accelerants when applied to dry tinder,

paper, cotton balls, or small kindling.

A cotton ball coated with lip balm can burn significantly longer than untreated tinder, helping ignite larger fuel in wet or windy conditions.

Petroleum-based lip balms typically burn hotter and longer than beeswax-only alternatives, though both can work in emergency fire-starting situations.

Even expired lip balm remains useful because the wax and petroleum ingredients continue functioning long after the printed expiration date.

#19 How to Turn a Paper Clip into a Fishing Hook, Emergency Repair Tool, or Compass

A paper clip can function as a fishing hook, repair needle, gear fastener, or improvised survival tool during emergencies.

Straighten the metal wire and bend the tip into a hook shape to create a simple fishing hook—best for small fish, as the wire can bend under the weight of larger ones.

Sharpen the point on concrete or a rough rock, then tie it to dental floss or thin cordage for a compact emergency fishing rig.

A straightened paper clip also works as a sewing needle to repair torn gear or clothing, a replacement zipper pull for a broken pack or jacket, and a tool to clean small clogged openings on bottles or spray cans.

One more use most people don't know: Straighten a paper clip, rub it against fabric or a knife blade to magnetize it, then float it on a leaf in still water.

It will align north to south—a functional improvised compass when GPS is unavailable.

#20 How to Start a Fire with a Gum Wrapper and a Battery

A stick of gum could be the difference between a fire and hypothermia, but only if the wrapper is foil-backed, not wax paper.

The foil conducts the electricity, and the paper backing is what actually catches the flame.

Pure aluminum foil from the kitchen won't work.

Tear a thin strip and cut or pinch the center down to a narrow point—the bottleneck is what generates the heat.

Touch both ends simultaneously to the positive and negative terminals of a AA battery.

Protect your fingers with a glove or rag as the contact points get hot fast.

The narrow center ignites in one or two seconds. Have your tinder ready before you make contact.


SURVIVAL CAR KIT
READY HOUR
SURVIVAL KIT
47 CRUCIAL EMERGENCY ITEMS
READY HOUR
2,400 CALORIE
EMERGENCY RATIONS
High-energy, individually wrapped food bars
READY HOUR
EMERGENCY
DRINKING WATER
UP TO 5-YEAR SHELF LIFE

What Should You Have beyond Household Emergency Hacks?

Improvised survival hacks can buy you time during emergencies, but reliable gear and preparation are what truly increase your odds during extended crises.

Combining everyday household tools with purpose-built emergency supplies creates a stronger, more dependable preparedness plan.

These household hacks are smart.

But they're a bridge…not a foundation.

When seconds count and conditions are bad, purpose-built gear performs better and faster than improvised alternatives.

The right kit means you spend less time problem-solving and more time acting.

Here's where to start:

Tactical Fire Starting Kit by InstaFire when gum wrappers and lip balm won't cut it

Survival Car Kit so everything you need in your vehicle is ready to go

MyFAK First Aid Kit — 111 Pieces because maxi pads can only do so much Build the foundation first.

Then add the household hacks as your backup layer.

What household hack do you rely on that didn't make our list? Drop it in the comments below.

In liberty,

Elizabeth Anderson

Preparedness Advisor, My Patriot Supply